

Justification Forensic

doc-justification-forensic

Soteriology · Justification · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Justification is God's declarative act of pardoning the sinner and accepting him as righteous on account of Christ, received by faith.

In plain language

The whole question turns on one verb and the word it is set against. The Greek verb 'to justify' (dikaioo, used 39 times in the New Testament) and the Hebrew verb it grows out of, 'to be righteous' (tsadaq) in its causative form, are repeatedly placed in flat opposition to the verbs that mean condemn. In Deuteronomy 25:1 the judges are to justify the righteous and condemn the wicked. Proverbs 17:15 calls justifying the wicked and condemning the righteous both an abomination. In 1 Kings 8:32 God as judge condemns the wicked and justifies the righteous. Romans 8:33 and 34 put it in two breaths: it is God who justifies, who is the one to condemn? Condemning is plainly a sentence handed down, never a remaking of a person on the inside, so its exact opposite, justifying, must also be a verdict handed down. That single fact is the strongest evidence, because the meaning of a word is fixed partly by its opposite. A second clue clinches it: Romans 4:5 says God justifies the ungodly ('the ungodly', ton asebe), and faith is reckoned to him as righteousness using an accounting word ('to reckon', logizomai). If the verb meant to make a person actually good, you could not call him ungodly in the same breath. Luke 18:14 shows the tax collector going home justified though nothing inside him had changed, only his standing before God. The honest counter-reading notes that this verb can sometimes mean to make or to cause, the way other verbs of its type do, and that justifying sits near washing and sanctifying in some lists. That reading is real and is why some diverge. But the very same form, in the courtroom texts and in justifying the ungodly, cannot mean make, since a judge does not infuse goodness into a guilty man. So the words land on a declared standing, granted on the basis of Christ and received by faith.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H6662	רָצַד	tsaddiq	righteous	
H6663	רָצָה	tsadaq	to justify	41
H7561	רָשָׁע	rasha'	be wicked	35
H7563	רָשָׁע	rasah	wicked	
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0268	ἁμαρτωλός	hamartōlos	sinful	
G0629	ἀπολύτρωσις	apolytrōsis	redemption	10
G0765	ἀσεβής	asebēs	ungodly	9
G1342	δίκαιος	dikaios	just	79

G1343	δικαιοσύνη	dikaiosynē	righteousness	91
G1344	δικαιόω	dikaioō	to justify	39
G1345	δικαίωμα	dikaiōma	righteous act	10
G1347	δικαίωσις	dikaiōsis	justification	2
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2525	καθίστημι	kathistēmi	to appoint/conduct	21
G2613	καταδικάζω	katadikazō	to condemn	5
G2631	κατάκριμα	katakrima	condemnation	3
G2632	κατακρίνω	katakrinō	to condemn	17
G2917	κρίμα	krima	judgment	
G2920	κρίσις	krisis	judgment	
G3049	λογίζομαι	logizomai	to count	40
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuō	to trust (in)	241
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The decisive datum is the antonym pairing. Both the Hebrew verb meaning 'to be righteous' (tsadaq) in the Hebrew causative form (Hiphil, the Hebrew causative form, to cause to do) (H6663, to declare righteous) and the Greek verb 'to justify' (dikaioo) (G1344, 39 occurrences) stand in fixed antithesis to the condemn verbs (Hebrew 'to be wicked' (rasha) in the Hebrew causative form (Hiphil) H7561, Greek 'to condemn' (katakrino) G2632 and 'to give an adverse judgement' (katadikazo) G2613). Deuteronomy 25:1, Proverbs 17:15, and 1 Kings 8:32 set 'to declare righteous' (hitsdiq) against 'to declare wicked' (hirshia) as the two verdicts a judge renders, and Romans 8:33-34 places 'the one justifying' (ho dikaion) directly opposite 'the one condemning' (ho katakrinon) in adjacent clauses. Since condemnation is a sentence pronounced and not a moral state infused, its antonym is likewise a verdict pronounced. Romans 4:5 seals it: God justifies 'the ungodly' (ton asebe) and faith is reckoned (logizetai, G3049) as righteousness, so the standing changes while the person is still ungodly, which a make-righteous reading cannot hold.

Scripture

Deut.25.1 · **for** · **genre: law**

Key terms. H6663 צדק, H7561 רשע

Reasoning. When men go to court the judges are to justify the righteous ('and they shall declare righteous', wehitsdiq, H6663 in the Hebrew causative form (Hiphil, the Hebrew causative form, to cause to do)) and condemn the wicked ('and they shall declare wicked', wehirshiu, H7561 in the Hiphil, the Hebrew causative form). The two verbs are the two verdicts a court issues. The Hiphil (Hebrew causative) stem here is causative in form but plainly declarative in sense, since a judge does not morally remake the litigant standing before him, he renders a sentence. This is the Hebrew matrix the Greek verb inherits.

Prov.17.15 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6663 צדק, H7561 רשע

Reasoning. One justifying the wicked ('one declaring the wicked righteous', matsdiq rasha, H6663 Hiphil (Hebrew causative form) participle) and one condemning the righteous ('one declaring the righteous wicked', marshia tsaddiq, H7561 Hiphil (Hebrew causative form) participle) are both an abomination to the LORD. A bribed or corrupt judge cannot literally infuse righteousness into a guilty man, so to justify here can only mean to pronounce an unwarranted verdict. The verse is decisive against a make-righteous reading of the Hiphil (Hebrew causative form).

1Kgs.8.32 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6663 צדק, H7561 רשע

Reasoning. Solomon prays that God as judge will act, to condemn the wicked ('to declare the wicked wicked', leharshia rasha) and to justify the righteous ('and to declare the righteous righteous', ulehatsdiq tsaddiq), giving each according to his way. The antithetical verdict pair is here predicated of God himself in the heavenly court, the prototype of Romans 8:33. God justifying does not mean God morally transforming in that act but God declaring a standing.

Rom.8.33 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. 'Who will bring a charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies' (tis enkalēsei kata eklekton theou; theos ho dikaion). Who will bring a legal charge against God's elect? It is God who justifies ('the one justifying', ho dikaion, the ongoing-action participle of the Greek verb to justify, G1344). The verb sits inside explicit courtroom vocabulary ('to lay a legal charge', enkalēo) and answers the charge with a verdict, not with a moral change.

Rom.8.34 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2632 κατακρίνω, G5547 Χριστός

Reasoning. 'Who is the one condemning? Christ is the one who died' (tis ho katakrinon; Christos ho apothanon). Who is the one condemning ('the one condemning', ho katakrinon, G2632)? Set immediately after 'the one justifying' (ho dikaion) in 8:33, this makes justify and condemn the matched pair of opposing verdicts. Because condemnation is indisputably a sentence pronounced and not a state infused, the antonymic justify in the prior verse is likewise declarative. This adjacency is the single clearest lexical proof of the forensic (law-court) sense.

Luke.18.14 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω

Reasoning. 'This one went down to his house having been justified' (katebe houtos dedikaiomenos eis ton oikon autou). The tax collector went down to his house justified ('having been justified', dedikaiomenos, the completed-action-with-standing-result participle of the Greek verb to justify, G1344) rather than the Pharisee. Nothing in the man changed morally between his prayer and his walk home, yet he is now in a settled justified standing. The act is a declared verdict received, in narrative outside Paul, which widens the pattern beyond the epistles.

Rom.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G0765 ἀσεβής, G3049 λογίζομαι

Reasoning. 'But to the one not working, but believing on the one justifying the ungodly, his faith is reckoned as righteousness' (to de me ergazomeno, pisteuonti de epi ton dikaiounta ton asebe, logizetai he pistis autou eis dikaiosynen). God justifies ('the one justifying', dikaiounta, G1344) the ungodly ('the ungodly', ton asebe, G0765) and faith is reckoned ('is reckoned', logizetai, G3049, the ledger or accounting verb) as righteousness. The verb is applied to a person still labelled ungodly at that very moment, which a make-morally-righteous gloss renders self-contradictory. The accounting verb 'to reckon' (logizomai, 40 occurrences, dense in Romans 4) supplies the imputational (credited-to-the-account), status-crediting register.

Rom.3.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαίω, G0629 ἀπολύτρωσις, G5547 Χριστός

Reasoning. 'Being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus' (dikaioumenoi dorean te autou chariti dia tes apolytroseos tes en Christo lesou). Ongoing-action passive participle of the Greek verb to justify (G1344), freely ('as a free gift', dorean), by grace, through the redemption ('release by ransom', apolytrosis, G0629) in Christ. The verb is grounded in ransom and atonement vocabulary, a legal-sacrificial ground for a verdict, not the language of internal moral cleansing.

Rom.3.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1342 δίκαιος, G1344 δικαίω, G4100 πιστεύω

Reasoning. 'So that he might be just and the one justifying the one who is of the faith of Jesus' (eis to einai auton dikaion kai dikaionta ton ek pisteos lesou). God is at once just ('righteous', dikaion, G1342) and the one justifying ('the one justifying', dikaionta, G1344) the believer. A judge can be simultaneously just and the one who acquits the guilty party only on a declarative reading where the ground of the verdict lies in the propitiation (wrath-averting sacrifice) just named (3:25), not on a reading where the same act makes the defendant intrinsically righteous.

Rom.5.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαίω, G4100 πιστεύω

Reasoning. 'Therefore having been justified out of faith we have peace toward God' (Dikaiothentes oun ek pisteos eirenen echomen pros ton theon). Completed-past-action passive participle of the Greek verb to justify (G1344): having been justified out of faith, we have peace toward God. The aorist (a completed past action) marks a completed punctiliar (single, point-in-time) act and the result is a changed relational standing (peace, reconciliation), the profile of a verdict rendered rather than a moral process underway.

Rom.5.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1347 δικαίωσις, G2631 κατάκριμα

Reasoning. 'Through one trespass to all men unto condemnation, so also through one righteous act to all men unto justification of life' (di henos paraptomatos eis pantas anthropous eis katakrima, houtos kai di henos dikaiomatos eis pantas anthropous eis dikaiosin zoes). The noun 'justification' (dikaiosis, G1347, only 2 occurrences, both Romans) is set in direct parallel against 'condemnation' (katakrima, G2631, condemnation, 3 occurrences, all Romans). Since 'condemnation' (katakrima) is uncontestably a sentence pronounced, its parallel partner 'justification' (dikaiosis) is a corresponding favourable verdict, not an infusion. The noun pair confirms what the verb pair shows.

Rom.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 καθίστημι, G1342 δίκαιος, G0268 ἁματωλός

Reasoning. 'The many were constituted sinners ... the many will be constituted righteous' (hamartoloi katestathesan hoi polloi ... dikaioi katastathesontai hoi polloi). The verb 'to constitute or appoint to a status' (kathistemi, G2525, to constitute or appoint to a status) governs both clauses. The many were constituted sinners through one man's disobedience as a legal-representative status, and the many are constituted righteous through one man's obedience in the same constitutive (status-conferring) sense. The symmetry forbids reading the second as moral infusion unless the first is moral infusion, which the one-act-of-one-man frame excludes.

2Cor.5.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G0266 ἁμαρτία, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. 'The one not knowing sin he made sin on our behalf, so that we might become God's righteousness in him' (ton me gnonta hamartian hyper hemon hamartian epoiesen, hina hemeis genometha dikaiosyne theou en auto). A double exchange: the sinless one was made sin for us so that we might become God's righteousness ('righteousness', dikaiosyne) in him ('in him', en auto, locative, marking position or sphere). Christ was not turned into a sinner intrinsically (he knew no sin), so by the controlled parallel our becoming righteousness is likewise a reckoned, relational standing located in Christ, not an infused quality.

Phil.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G3551 νόμος, G4100 πιστεύω

Reasoning. 'Not having my own righteousness, the one out of law, but the one through faith of Christ, the righteousness out of God upon the faith' (me echon emen dikaiosynen ten ek nomou, alla ten dia pisteos Christou, ten ek theou dikaiosynen epi te pistei). An explicit contrast between my own righteousness ('righteousness', dikaiosyne) from law ('my own ... from law', emen ... ek nomou) and the righteousness from God ('from God', ek theou) received through faith. The repeated prepositions of source ('from law', ek nomou, versus 'from God', ek theou) frame the righteousness as conferred from outside the believer, received not produced.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.3.21	Rom.1.17	tsk	1
Rom.4.5	Rom.4.3	tsk	1
Rom.4.5	Rom.1.17	tsk	1
Rom.3.25	Exod.25.17	tsk	1
Rom.3.25	Rom.3.26	tsk	1
Rom.3.25	Rom.5.1	tsk	1
Rom.3.24	Rom.5.9	tsk	1
Rom.5.19	Isa.53.10	tsk	1
2Cor.5.21	Isa.53.9	tsk	1
2Cor.5.21	Isa.53.4	tsk	1
Phil.3.9	Phil.3.6	tsk	1
Phil.3.9	Ps.71.15	tsk	1
Rom.3.26	Deut.32.4	tsk	1
Rom.3.23	Rom.3.9	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Rom.5.19 · addressed

The verb 'to constitute or appoint' (kathistemi, G2525) can mean to appoint or to make, and a transformative reader takes 'the many will be constituted righteous' (dikaioi katastathesontai) as being made actually righteous. Read against its own parallel, the same verb in the same verse says the many were constituted sinners through Adam, which the one-act frame cannot mean an infusion of personal sin into each individual at that moment. So the symmetrical second clause is a constitutive (status-conferring), status-conferring sense, not moral remaking. The complication is real at the verb level but resolved by the immediate parallel.

Jas.2.24 · addressed

'You see that out of works a person is justified and not out of faith only' (horate hoti ex ergon dikaioantai anthropos kai ouk ek pisteos monon). James uses 'to justify' (dikaioo, G1344) of Abraham at the binding of Isaac (Genesis 22), the demonstration of a faith credited long before in Genesis 15:6. The verb keeps its declarative sense in James, a vindication shown to be genuine, but the audience of the declaration shifts toward observable evidence. James never uses 'to justify' (dikaioo) for moral cleansing, so even this text does not yield a transformative sense of the verb.

1Cor.6.11 · addressed

'You were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified' (apelousasthe, hegiasthete, edikaiothete). Three completed-past-action passives in a row: you were washed, sanctified, justified. The fact that 'to justify' (dikaioo, G1344) stands as a distinct item beside 'to sanctify or set apart as holy' (hagiazō) shows Paul does not collapse justification into the cleansing or sanctifying verbs. The distinct listing preserves the forensic (law-court) verb as its own category rather than as a synonym for moral transformation.

Rom.6.7 · addressed

'For the one who has died has been justified from sin' (ho gar apothanon dedikaiotai apo tes hamartias). The completed-action-with-standing-result passive of 'to justify' (dikaioo) with 'from' (apo, freed from) is read by some as transformative liberation from sin's power. It reads equally as the forensic (law-court) register, the one who has died is acquitted of, or released from, sin's legal claim. Romans uses the verb uniformly forensically at 5:1, 5:9, 8:30, and 8:33, so the legal-release sense is the better fit, and either reading remains declarative-relational rather than infused.

Concordance traversed

G1344, G1343, G1342, G1347, G1345, G3049, G2632, G2613, G2631, G2525, G2917, G2920, G0765, G0629, G4100, H6663, H7561, H6662, H7563

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle and the anchor texts fall outside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15), so not_in_ecm_scope holds. The cited Pauline verses carry known minor variants (word-order and the reading at Romans 3:22, Western expansions at Romans 3:24-25, the article at 2 Corinthians 5:21) but none disturbs the dik- root verb or noun (the 'righteous' or 'justify' word family), the ledger verb 'to reckon' (logizomai) at Romans 4, or the 'condemnation' (katakrima) parallel at Romans 5:18. The verdict holds across the realistic spread of readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. forensic_declarative_lens, transformative_infusion_lens, covenant_membership_lens, apocalyptic_rectification_lens

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

forensic_declarative_lens: Strongly affirms. Justification is a verdict of acquittal and accepted standing, grounded in Christ's atonement and the reckoning of righteousness, not an infusion of moral quality. · The Greek verb 'to justify' (dikaioo, G1344) is fixed in antithesis to the condemn verbs 'to condemn' (katakrimo, G2632) and 'to give an adverse judgement' (katadikazo, G2613), with Romans 8:33-34 setting 'the one justifying' (ho dikaion) against 'the one condemning' (ho katakrinon). The Hebrew causative form (Hiphil, the Hebrew causative form, to cause to do) of 'to be righteous' (tsadaq, H6663) versus 'to be wicked' (rasha, H7561) at Deuteronomy 25:1, Proverbs 17:15, and 1 Kings 8:32 supplies the same courtroom pair. Romans 4:5 applies the verb to the ungodly with the ledger verb 'to reckon' (logizomai). The semantic field is the law court, so the act is a declared verdict.

transformative_infusion_lens: Reads dikaioo causatively as to make righteous, so justification begins or includes a real interior renewal, with sanctification not sharply separable from it. · This is the strongest form of the minority

reading. Greek verbs in the -oo (the verbal ending often expressing 'cause to be X') family can be factitive (making the object what the root names) or causative (for example 'to enslave' (douloo) and 'to free' (eleutheroo) effect a real change), so to make righteous is morphologically possible, and texts like 1 Corinthians 6:11 list justification beside washing and sanctifying, and Romans 5:19 uses 'to constitute or appoint' (kathistemi) (to constitute or make). The lens takes righteousness language to describe an imparted condition rather than only a credited status. The lexical pressure against it is that the very same Hiphil (Hebrew causative form) and -oo (Greek causative-shaped) stems in Deuteronomy 25:1, Proverbs 17:15, and Romans 4:5 must be declarative there (a judge cannot infuse righteousness into the guilty, and the ungodly is still ungodly when justified), which caps how much the causative morphology can carry.

covenant_membership_lens: Affirms a declarative sense but takes the content of the declaration to be inclusion in God's covenant people rather than the crediting of an alien righteousness. · On this reading 'to justify' (dikaioo) still names a verdict, not a transformation, so it agrees that the verb is declarative. The dispute is over what is declared (membership and right standing in the covenant community versus imputed (credited from outside) righteousness), and the antithesis with the condemn verbs is preserved either way, since exclusion or condemnation is the opposing verdict.

apocalyptic_rectification_lens: Affirms God's dikaiosyne as a saving, world-righting verdict enacted in Christ's faithful death, declarative in character and external in source. · This lens stresses 'God's righteousness' (dikaiosyne theou) (Romans 3:21-26) as God's own saving action rather than a moral attribute produced in the believer, which keeps the righteousness alien (from outside the person), conferred, and verdict-shaped, consistent with the forensic (law-court) verb usage even while reframing its scope.

The genuine lexical contest is forensic-declarative (the law-court verdict reading) against transformative-infusion (the inwardly-made-righteous reading). The covenant-membership and apocalyptic lenses both land on the declarative side and differ only over the content and scope of the declaration. The decisive constraint is that the antonym of 'to justify' (dikaioo) across both Testaments is a condemn verb, and condemnation is never an infusion, so the matched term is a verdict. The transformative lens is represented in its strongest morphological form (the causative -oo (Greek verbal ending) and Hiphil (Hebrew causative form) stems) and is not strawmanned, but the same stems are demonstrably declarative where the object is the ungodly or where a judge is the subject.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition asks whether justification is God's declarative act of pardoning and accepting the sinner as righteous on Christ's account, received by faith. This is the lexical-semantic (word-meaning) question of whether 'to justify' (dikaioo) and its Hebrew counterpart denote a declared verdict or an effected moral change, which is the object of investigation rather than a smuggled conclusion. The stem does not encode a tradition-specific taxonomy. Prior affirms true is retained: the queried data strengthen rather than overturn it, so no VERDICT-CHANGED: tag is warranted.

Citations

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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1344
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2632
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morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.5.18-19
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